

Immunotherapy for mesothelioma

You may be offered immunotherapy to treat mesothelioma.

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About immunotherapy for mesothelioma

The immune system protects the body against illness and infection. Immunotherapies are treatments that use the immune system to find and attack cancer cells.

You may be offered immunotherapy to treat pleural or peritoneal mesothelioma. It is usually used as a first treatment for pleural mesothelioma.

The most common immunotherapy drugs used for mesothelioma are called [nivolumab](#) and [ipilimumab](#). They are usually [given together](#). These drugs are also called [checkpoint inhibitors](#) or CPIs.

Sometimes nivolumab may be offered on its own to some people who have pleural mesothelioma and who already had chemotherapy and need further treatment.

Your cancer team will explain if this treatment is suitable for you.

How immunotherapy is given

Immunotherapy drugs for pleural mesothelioma and peritoneal mesothelioma are given into a vein (intravenously).

How often and how long you have immunotherapy for depends on:

- the type of immunotherapy you are given
- how your body reacts to the treatment
- whether the immunotherapy is working effectively.

Your cancer team will explain how often you will have them.

Side effects of immunotherapy

Checkpoint inhibitor drugs can have a range of side effects. Your cancer team will give you information about possible side effects before you start treatment. You may get some of the side effects but you are unlikely to get all of them.

Your cancer team will monitor you regularly during and after treatment. They can give you drugs to help control some side effects and advice on how to manage them. It is important to take any drugs exactly as explained. This means they will be more likely to work for you.

Immune-related side effects

Immunotherapy drugs can attack healthy tissue and make the immune system react. This can cause inflammation in different organs of the body. Sometimes this causes very serious side effects called immune related side effects.

Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist will explain the possible side effects and what to do if you have any. It is very important to know about them so you can contact the hospital straight away. You will need to be treated quickly. Do not try to treat this type of side effect yourself.

Some of the organs or parts of the body that might be affected include:

- the liver
- the lungs
- the bowel
- the kidneys
- glands that make certain hormones
- the joints
- the skin.

If you think you have any of these side effects, contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number you have been given.

Immune system side effects can start in the first weeks or months of treatment. But sometimes they happen up to 2 years after treatment has finished.

Sometimes your doctor may delay treatment until side effects improve. If you have serious side effects your doctor may advise stopping the treatment. They can talk to you about other possible treatment options.

Contacting the hospital

Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist will give you 24-hour contact numbers for the hospital. If you feel unwell or need advice, you can call at any time of the day or night. Save these numbers in your phone or keep them somewhere safe.

Sometimes side effects can become serious very quickly. Always contact the hospital straight away for advice.

Always have your patient alert card with you during treatment and after treatment ends.

About our information

This information has been written, revised and edited by Macmillan Cancer Support's Cancer Information Development team. It has been reviewed by expert medical and health professionals and people living with cancer.

References



Below is a sample of the sources used in our mesothelioma cancer information. If you would like more information about the sources we use, please contact us at informationproductionteam@macmillan.org.uk

Kusamura S, Kepenekian V, Villeneuve L, Lurvink RJ, Govaerts K, De Hingh IHJT, Moran BJ, Van der Speeten K, Deraco M, Glehen O; PSOGI. Peritoneal mesothelioma: PSOGI/EURACAN clinical practice guidelines for diagnosis, treatment and follow-up. Eur J Surg Oncol. 2021 Vol, 47(1) pp6-59. [accessed April 2024].

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Our cancer information meets the [PIF TICK](#) quality mark.

This means it is easy to use, up-to-date and based on the latest evidence. Learn more about [how we produce our information](#).

The language we use

We want everyone affected by cancer to feel our information is written for them.

We want our information to be as clear as possible. To do this, we try to:

- use plain English
- explain medical words
- use short sentences
- use illustrations to explain text
- structure the information clearly
- make sure important points are clear.

We use gender-inclusive language and talk to our readers as 'you' so that everyone feels included. Where clinically necessary we use the terms 'men' and 'women' or 'male' and 'female'. For example, we do so when talking about parts of the body or mentioning statistics or research about who is affected.

You can read more about how we produce our information [here](#).

How we can help

Clinical Information Nurse Specialists

Our Cancer Information Nurse Specialists are dedicated cancer nurses available to talk to on our Macmillan Cancer Support Line.



Call us free on 0808 808 0000

8am to 8pm, 7 days a week. You can talk to our cancer specialists about anything.



Email the Macmillan Support Line

Email the Macmillan Support Team if you have any questions.

Chat online

Available 8am to 7.45pm, 7 days a week. For confidential, real-time support if you don't want to call.



Online Community

An anonymous network of people affected by mesothelioma which is free to join. Share experiences, ask questions and talk to people who understand.



Find cancer support services in your area

What's going on near you? Find out about support groups, where to get information and how to get involved with Macmillan where you live

Get help